

How Do You See the Domestic "Base" (Basic Share)?

Zhihu

I only came across this term recently. In the comments it is most likely used to refer to people who support the government's policies and propaganda unconditionally.

The so-called base is roughly those who get excited watching "Amazing, My Country" or "The Rise of the Great Powers," who like any article from self-media bragging that China is bound to win, and who side one-sidedly with Russia. To people standing in a critical position, these people are utterly devoid of reason, hence the name "base" — meaning that arguing with them is pointless.

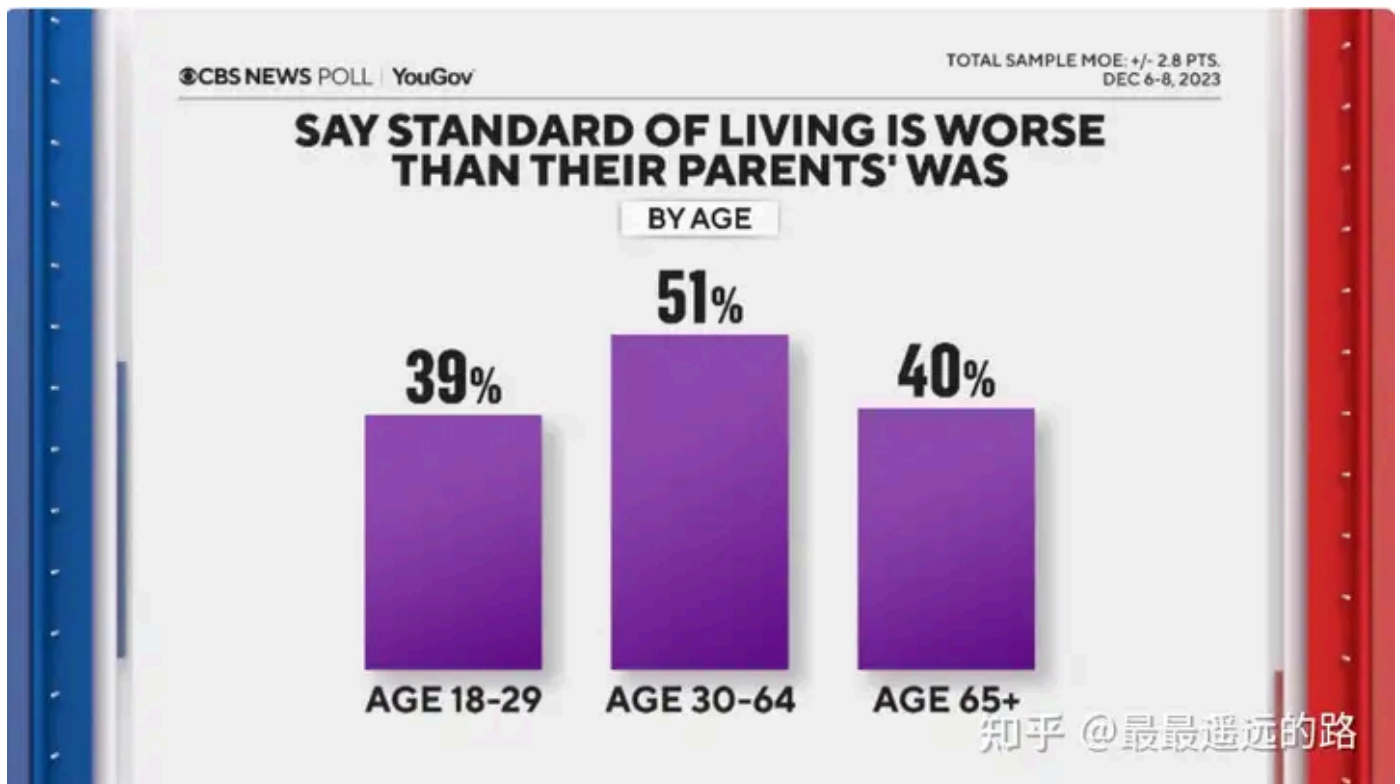
How should we view the base?

If we drop our positions and start from the facts, we must admit that the existence of the base is an objective phenomenon. China is not alone in having one; almost every country has it, and it is especially numerous in developing countries with good economic growth. If you look at YouTube, you will find plenty of base-type commenters in India, Vietnam, and even Egypt and Ethiopia.

The so-called base consists of those who feel they have benefited from the current social structure. When people judge whether the current political and economic system works in their favour, they do not compare themselves with foreigners, nor with the rich; they compare with their own past life — especially their childhood and the living conditions of their parents' generation. Or they may feel that, though their own generation is what it is, their children's generation will live better; either way, it produces hope and identification with the current system.

Why is the American base shrinking more and more? Politically, polarisation is intensifying, putting people like Trump in the presidency and at the same time electing a number of DSA members to Congress and to the mayoralities of major cities. The root cause is that more and more Americans feel their lives have worsened relative to their childhood and to their parents' generation. At the same time, more parents believe their children's living standards will be worse than their own.

A 2023 survey found that a majority of the core working-age population, 30–64, believe their living standards are worse than their parents'.



Source: <https://www.cbsnews.com/news/cbs-news-poll-inflation-impact-living-standards-opportunity-2023-12-10/>

Another survey found that only 37% of parents believe their children will live better than themselves.

Source: <https://www.nbcnews.com/business/consumer/only-37-percent-americans-think-their-kids-will-be-better-n768706>

These American survey results in fact reflect a global phenomenon. A global Pew survey last year showed that people in almost all developed countries think their children's generation will have lower living standards than their own. In the industrialised countries that have basically completed industrialisation and urbanisation — Turkey, Malaysia, Brazil, Mexico — opinions vary considerably. But in most developing countries — India, Bangladesh, Indonesia, the Philippines — people believe their children's economic situation will be better than their own.

Source: <https://www.pewresearch.org/global/2025/01/09/views-of-childrens-financial-future/>

Why is this so?

Because after industrialisation is completed, the logic of workers' income in modern society has changed relative to pre-modern society. The peasant of pre-modern society struggled with nature: the more his land yielded, the more grain he kept for himself — whether tenant or smallholder — and the better his life. But the worker of today's society can produce more without his income necessarily rising. The growth of real wages after inflation is not automatically linked to productivity growth; it is the outcome of struggle between workers and capital.

The chart below shows the curves of American labour productivity and real wages. Clearly, before the 1980s — especially before the 1970s — wage growth kept pace with productivity growth; after 1980,

productivity growth has far outstripped wage growth: productivity rose 87.3% while real wages rose only 32.7%. (Some earlier reports I have seen say American workers' real wages have stagnated since the neoliberal reforms of the 1980s.) In countries like Italy in southern Europe, real wages have even fallen.

Source: <https://www.epi.org/productivity-pay-gap/>

The reason the base is so numerous among Indians, Indonesians, and Filipinos is that these countries are undergoing rapid urbanisation — peasants turning from ultra-low-income farmers into low-income workers.

For example, the monthly income of an Indian farming household, according to the Indian government's 2021 statistics, averages out — pooling poor, lower-middle, and rich peasants — to at most 10,000 rupees, less than 800 yuan in RMB. Note this is household income, not individual income: even with two workers per family, each worker earns less than 400 yuan a month; for the landless and land-poor peasants among them, monthly income is only two or three hundred yuan.

Source: <https://www.pib.gov.in/PressReleasePage.aspx?PRID=1753856®=3&lang=2>

Once these peasants enter the cities, what wages do they get? The national average wage has already reached 22,000 rupees, about 1,700 yuan. North India pays less — Bihar, for example, only about 10,000 rupees, not much better than farming.

Source: <https://indiadatamap.com/2025/09/02/migrant-workers-in-india-economic-contributions-and-challenges/>

Migrant workers receive lower wages compared to local workers — on a national scale, ₹22,400 per month for migrants versus ₹28,000 for locals. In Delhi, migrants earn ₹28,000, while locals make ₹35,000. In Bihar, the figures are ₹10,800 for migrants compared to ₹13,500 for locals. Migrants typically earn 20–30% less due to their prevalence in informal employment sectors such as construction or street vending, which limits their bargaining power. In Kerala, migrant wages are relatively high at ₹19,600, driven by a strong demand in the construction industry. Source: <https://indiadatamap.com/2025/09/02/migrant-workers-in-india-economic-contributions-and-challenges/>

India has 150 million migrant workers. Because wages are high in South India and in the western states of Maharashtra and Gujarat, Indian peasants flock there to work — you may think of this region as India's equivalent of the Yangtze River Delta and Pearl River Delta.

Source: <https://indiadatamap.com/2025/09/02/migrant-workers-in-india-economic-contributions-and-challenges/>

Because going from the countryside to work in the cities can multiply one's wages several times over, bringing an improvement in living standards. Migrant workers build the high-rises, railways, and expressways in the cities, enter Foxconn and all manner of factories, and push India's productive

forces forward at a rapid pace — the whole society is suffused with a thriving spirit. This is the fundamental reason Modi keeps winning re-election.

India's story is now being replayed in Indonesia and in Vietnam. And on the soil of our motherland, this story began more than thirty years ago.

In the early 1990s, a peasant's annual income was only 650 yuan (National Bureau of Statistics: 1990), but the monthly wage of migrant work could reach 200 yuan, and by the mid-1990s, 500 yuan. Compared with farming, the income from migrant work was likewise multiplied several times over.

Source: <https://nsd.pku.edu.cn/attachments/6548c6f9e6314a4fb20a4efdec5ff4a2.pdf>

The majority of a country's people surge into the cities like a tide; per-capita income multiplies several-fold; living standards rise sharply. Though a vast mass of surplus value is still taken by international and domestic capital, and the work is very hard, the improvement in ordinary people's living standards is real, and the new houses built back home in the villages are real too. These peasants — and their children — who have experienced a leap in living standards are the base.

The fundamental principles of historical materialism are: the productive forces determine the relations of production, the economic base determines the superstructure, and social being determines social consciousness. If in a society the base constitutes an absolute majority, then the relations of production of that country still fit the development of its productive forces. And if in a society the base shrinks sharply, that can only mean the relations of production ought to change.

Our society is now close to completing its urbanisation, but most people spent their childhood as peasants, and the contrast between childhood and present living standards is stark. Although China's urbanisation rate passed 50% in 2010, household-registration (hukou) urbanisation has only now basically reached 50% (48.3% at the end of 2023; in 2025 it probably exceeds 50%). Hence, at present most children still attend primary and secondary school in the countryside, and not a few of them are the so-called "left-behind children."

Enrolment fell, markedly in rural areas and slightly up in cities. In 2020, national primary school intake was 18.081 million, down 610,000 (3.3%) from the previous year; of these, urban primary intake was 7.589 million, up 1.8%, while rural intake was 10.492 million, down 6.6%. National junior secondary intake was 16.321 million, down 68,000 (0.4%); urban junior secondary intake was 6.453 million, up 3.4%, rural intake 9.868 million, down 2.8%. Enrolment rose overall, markedly in cities and slightly down in rural areas. In 2020, total primary enrolment was 107.254 million, up 1.641 million (1.6%); urban primary enrolment was 42.031 million, up 6.0%, rural 65.223 million, down 1.1%. Total junior secondary enrolment was 49.141 million, up 870,000 (1.8%); urban 19.029 million, up 5.3%, rural 30.111 million, down 0.3%. Source: 2020 National Education Development — Ministry of Education of the PRC

The children born after 2025 will mostly have grown up in the cities. How their generation views the change in their living standards depends on whether China can smoothly complete its industrial upgrading and become a developed country. If it succeeds, the base will remain dominant; if it fails or stumbles, the base will loosen.

So, basically until 2050, as long as there is no mass unemployment (overall unemployment above 10%) or hyperinflation (say, prices rising more than 50% in a short period), the broadly defined base in China will keep its majority. The same holds for other countries undergoing rapid industrialisation and urbanisation.

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